Army assistance, as early as 8–9 February. However, to do so we would require a formal requisition asking for our assistance in 'aid to civil authority', as well as clearance from the MoD, which is dependent on a similar requisition from the MHA. This was absolutely mandatory, as otherwise, falsehoods are raised about the Army attempting a 'coup', which kind of controversy is best avoided.

At Rohtak, the protestors had laid siege to the city, not allowing anyone to move in or out. They indulged in acts of arson and violence, including setting on fire the residence of Shri Abhimanyu Singh, the state finance minister (brother of Capt RS Sindhu of my unit). The nearest Army troops were those of 31 Armoured Division based at Hissar, and these troops were mobilized, but the agitators had anticipated this move and blocked the roads. It was then decided to send columns of 22 Infantry Division from the garrison at Delhi, which came under 2 Corps. These columns also found their way along the main roads blocked, but by making several detours and using smaller village roads, one or two columns managed to reach Rohtak. However, this strength was not adequate and additional columns were ferried in by helicopter into a large ground, which had been converted into a makeshift control centre. Since the columns had been flown in, they did not have any vehicles and had to carry out the flag marches on foot. These flag marches did much to restore the peace as well as the confidence of the local population. As several government forces were milling about, and due to the similarities in the uniform, it was often difficult to make out which were the Army columns. Nevertheless, our boys did a wonderful job. I too flew in during the initial days of the deployment and I was disheartened to see the extent of the damage. I could feel the palpable sense of fear among the locals and civil administration.

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